

THE GIRL, THOUGH SECRETLY MARRIED TO HER BOYFRIEND, WAS GETTING ENGAGED TO A MORE "SUITABLE BOY" CHOSEN BY HER PARENTS. WE TRAILED HER AND FOUND OUT.

A.M. MALATHY, 39

HEAD OF: Women's Detective Bureau, Chennai

FIRST CASE: As an engineering student, had stunned the detectives her family had appointed, to solve a property case, with her sleuthing skills.

PERSONALITY QUIRK: Doing different things every day

JOB PROFILE: Matrimonial and teen issues, theft in family, blackmailing, stalking, employment and asset verification

was an unmarried son who was cleverly manipulating events to incriminate the new bride. Lahiri mentions a society woman, seemingly upset about her husband's philandering ways, who turned out to be the one having affairs. Paliwal rescued a 13-year-old girl abducted by a gang of flesh traders. "I cracked the case and with the help of Delhi Police raided their hideout in Orissa," says Paliwal.

Trust, the bedrock of conjugality, seems to be on a slide. Nearly 75 per cent of Malathy's clients are involved in immoral relationships, acrimonious divorces or bitter tussles over money ("Money and greed play a big role between men and women, these days").

boys meet up, fall in love and routinely engage a sleuth to check each other out. Paliwal recalls a young computer engineer who turned out to be a womanising alcoholic. "The hardest part was in telling his girl friend. She was hopelessly in love." Given that arranged marriages are the bedrock of Indian society, a lot of cases involve pre-marital checks. If one set of parents wants to be sure that the man they have chosen for their daughter is indeed the MBA that he claims to be, another set wishes to be certain that the chosen bride-to-be has no skeletons in the cupboard. Nearly 60 per cent of Pandit's cases are on troubled teens. "Parents want to know why children

H. K. RAJASHEKAR



"Most people are really not what they usually seem to be..."

A young girl who, though secretly married to her boyfriend, got engaged to a more "suitable boy" chosen by her parents. "We shadowed her and the marriage was called off," she says. Lahiri also notices a new streak of aggressive materialism among the middle class: "They are more concerned with the bank balance of a prospective partner than his character."

Love is the other casualty. Girls and

have suddenly become rebellious or strange." Pandit cracked a case where a group of college boys in Mumbai were administering sleeping pills to parents and slipping out quietly to tamper with question papers in college. "Ironically, anxious parents often refuse to accept negative reports."

Women sleuths are not in agreement over the question of whether their gender is an advantage or a stum-